6 Excel Tools to Become Disgustingly Good at Finance

What each tool is, how to use it, and when it gets used.

1. Macabacus

The shortcut layer every banker installs on day one.

WHAT IT IS

An Excel add-in for building, formatting, and auditing models fast. It adds keyboard shortcuts for formatting cycles, number formats, and navigation, plus tools to trace precedents and dependents and to link Excel outputs straight into PowerPoint and Word.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Install the add-in and load your firm's formatting standards (fonts, number formats, colors for inputs vs. formulas).
2. Use the format cycles (number, date, color, borders) to format whole blocks of a model in a few keystrokes.
3. Trace precedents and dependents to follow a formula across sheets without clicking through every cell.
4. Run the model checks to flag hard-coded numbers, inconsistent formulas, and errors before anything goes out.
5. Link tables and charts to PowerPoint so pitch book pages update when the model changes.

WHEN IT IS USED

Investment banking analyst work, pitch books, and any model that needs to look clean and get built fast.

2. S&P Capital IQ Plug-in

Live market data and financials, pulled straight into your cells.

WHAT IT IS

The Excel plug-in for S&P Capital IQ. It lets you pull company financials, market data, consensus estimates, and transaction data into a spreadsheet with formulas, so comps and models refresh with current numbers instead of manual copy-paste.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Log in through the plug-in with your firm's Capital IQ subscription.
2. Use the formula builder (or functions like =CIQ) to pull a metric by ticker, data item, and period.
3. Build a comps sheet that pulls share price, diluted shares, debt, cash, revenue, and EBITDA for every peer.
4. Use the built-in templates for tear sheets, comps, and financial statements as a starting point.
5. Refresh the workbook to update every number at once, and spot-check key figures against filings.

WHEN IT IS USED

Trading comps, precedent transactions, pitch book data pages, and keeping any public-company model current.

3. Daloopa

Model-ready fundamentals, with every number traced to its source.

WHAT IT IS

A fundamental data platform that uses AI to extract historical financials and company-specific KPIs from filings and investor presentations. Each data point links back to the exact page it came from, and an Excel add-in updates your model when a company reports.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Search for the company and review the historical data set, including segment and KPI detail.
2. Pull the data into Excel through the add-in, or map it into your existing model's rows.
3. Click any number to jump to its source document and verify it before relying on it.
4. When a new quarter is reported, run the update so the new actuals drop into your model.
5. Spend the saved time on forecasting and analysis instead of manual data entry.

WHEN IT IS USED

Equity research, hedge funds, earnings season model updates, and building detailed historicals fast.

4. Arixcel

See how a model really works before you trust it.

WHAT IT IS

An Excel add-in for formula auditing and model review. It shows a formula's full chain of precedents and dependents in one view, lets you jump between linked cells across sheets, and makes long nested formulas readable.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Open the model you are reviewing and select a key output, like enterprise value or IRR.
2. Use the precedents and dependents explorer to see every input that feeds that cell.
3. Navigate the formula chain sheet by sheet to confirm the logic matches the model's intent.
4. Look for broken links, hard-codes buried in formulas, and inconsistent ranges.
5. Document issues as you go and fix them before the model reaches a senior banker or a client.

WHEN IT IS USED

Reviewing someone else's model, checking your own work before sending, and diligence on inherited models.

5. Solver

Let Excel find the best answer under real constraints.

WHAT IT IS

An optimization tool that comes free with Excel. You set an objective cell to maximize, minimize, or hit a target, choose the input cells it can change, and add constraints. Unlike Goal Seek, it handles many inputs and limits at once.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Enable Solver under Excel Add-ins, then open it from the Data tab.
2. Set the objective cell, such as sponsor IRR, portfolio return, or total cost.
3. Choose the variable cells Solver can change, such as debt tranches or portfolio weights.
4. Add constraints, like a maximum leverage multiple, minimum interest coverage, or weights summing to 100%.
5. Pick a solving method (Simplex LP for linear problems, GRG Nonlinear for most others) and solve.

WHEN IT IS USED

LBO debt sizing, portfolio optimization, capital allocation, and solving for a price that hits a target return.

6. @RISK

Turn a single-point forecast into a range of outcomes.

WHAT IT IS

A Monte Carlo simulation add-in for Excel. Instead of one value per assumption, you give each key input a probability distribution, then run thousands of iterations to see the full range of possible outputs and which inputs drive them.

HOW TO USE IT

1. Pick the assumptions that matter most, like revenue growth, margins, and exit multiple.
2. Replace each with a distribution (normal, triangular, uniform) based on history or judgment.
3. Mark the outputs you care about, such as NPV, IRR, or equity value, as simulation outputs.
4. Run thousands of iterations to build a distribution of results.
5. Read the histograms, percentiles, and tornado charts to see the odds of hitting a target and the biggest risks.

WHEN IT IS USED

Project finance, capital budgeting, risk analysis, and stress-testing a DCF or LBO beyond a simple sensitivity table.

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